

AVOID NOTES (DON'T EXIST)

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #114

For years (decades) I heard about the "avoid notes" on a given chord, notes that don't sound as good as others. And yes, there is some truth to that way of thinking. Here is a partial list of awful sounding notes on a given chord.

- The 4th on a major 7 chord
- The minor 3rd on a major 7 chord
- The major 7th on a minor 7 chord
- The minor 7th on a major 7 chord
- The major 3rd on a minor 7 chord
- The major 7th on a dominant chord

Another word for "avoid" or "awful" is Interesting. Or Flavorful. Or Tense, or Suspensful. These notes should NOT be avoided. Rather, they should be understood and loved. They should be cared for and nurtured. These are the fun notes, the notes your mother warned you about. Sure, they might get you in trouble now and again, but when you learn what makes them tick, learn a bit about how they work and how they resolve, you will begin to see inside what makes all great art work . . . tension and release. You can't have the release without the tension, and tension (melodic tension anyway) comes from the "avoid notes."

The example below uses a number of "avoid notes" (highlighted with the "V" symbol above the notes head). The chord changes used in the example here were addressed in Digging Deeper #79, "How To Learn Tunes." They are based on Take The A Train/Girl From Impanema.

